temples are crumbling under its watch. Devotees' money must go toward preserving our sacred heritage, not funding the state's agenda. Our demand is simple: free our temples. Let the devotees, the true stakeholders, manage them."

Tamil writer Imayam, who serves as the vice-chairman of the TN SC/ST Commission, finds the idea of blocking temple money for education "not just wrong, but vicious". Tamil Nadu has "historically resisted and won" against the "push to privatise religion and turn temples into exclusive zones", says the Sahitya Akademi awardee. Indeed, temple funds gaining social purpose is no DMK innovation; way back in 1961, under Congress rule, surplus from the Palani temple helped set up the Palaniandavar College of Indian Culture.

Reeling a bit from the onslaught, EPS has since attempted to clarify his remarks. "I'm not against education," he said. "But when temples fund colleges, they often lack adequate facilities. Government-funded colleges are better equipped. That was my only point." But the framing of his original remarks has allowed the DMK to present the AIADMK's rhetoric as increasingly aligned with saffron—and anti-development.

Electorally, that can become an Achilles' heel for a substantial part of its vote base. Hitherto, it had been navigating through a zone of ambivalence. As the 2026 assembly election approaches, religion-oriented topics are likely to become even more politically charged, and the AIADMK may find it vexing to sail in two boats. For the DMK, it looks less troubling: an aggravation of the polity around religion only solidifies its base. ■

▶ MAHARASHTRA

WHEN POLITICS GOES SOUTH

A Shinde Sena MLA harks back to the old nativist credo, but only as a cover for a mess of his own making

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

Anti-South Indian politics was the very first drum roll with which the Shiv Sena arrived on the stage of modern Indian politics. It clearly still has some juice left, judging by the curious way it made a fresh entry into the headlines—as an afterthought to a thoughtless act tailor-made for endless TV. The protagonist was Sanjay Gaikwad, an Eknath Shinde Sena MLA whose nature, by all accounts, resembles a typical Mumbai weather report: torrential, always with chances of strong thunder. This particular downpour started after a video surfaced of Gaikwad, clad in a vest and a towel around his waist, punching a hapless staffer at the MLA hostel at Nariman Point.

FRESH HEADACHE FOR SHINDE

If anything, the issue has ended up becoming a blow to an already beleaguered Shinde, who finds himself increasingly cornered in the ruling Mahayuti alliance. The BJP is being adequately caustic about the deputy CM's inability to control his men, reviving the frequent characterisation of his Sena as a loose coalition of MLAs rather than a political party with a structure of command and internal checks and balances. The episode was shambolic enough to merit such a broad-brush taint.

In the video, Gaikwad, a second-term MLA from Buldhana in Vidarbha, is seen forcing a hostel employee to sniff dal in a carrybag, before punching him. The staffer at the Akashwani MLA hostel, right opposite Mantralaya in south Mumbai, falls. Gaikwad claims his fists of fury were goaded by poor quality dal and stale food, alleging that the canteen management is a repeat offender. The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) later inspected the canteen and suspended its licence.

Under fire for his lack of restraint, Gaikwad went on to burnish

POWER OVER PEOPLE A video grab of Shiv Sena MLA Sanjay Gaikwad slapping a canteen worker in Mumbai, Jul. 9

